

From the Battlefield to the Stage:  
The Cultural Transformation of Drums as a Military Tool to an Art Instrument.

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## Abstract

The goal of this research is to trace the evolution of the use of drums in the United States spanning from 1862 to 1945, identifying the transition from a military tool to relay commands to an instrument of art expression. The means of communication in the military in this period notably exemplifies the pivotal role of drums. With the rise of technological advancements, telecommunication became a more reliable, efficient, and faster way for communication not only on the battlefield but across borders rendering the drum usage of communicating ineffectual. An analysis was conducted on how drums were used in the Civil War, specifically the Battle of Shiloh, and how telecommunications in the post-Civil War era were utilized (WWI & II). This research highlights the significance of historical context, international comparisons, technological shifts, and the cultural impact of music, illuminating how seemingly simple instruments mirror broader societal changes, and revealing the intricate connections between history, culture, and technology. Furthermore, a comparative analysis of how other nations adapted to similar technological changes in their military communication methods would offer a broader perspective on this historical transformation.

During the American Civil War, Johnny Clem, a distinguished drummer boy had a remarkable impact in the Battle of Shiloh, also known as the Battle of Pittsburgh Landing in April 1862. It was one of the bloodiest battles between the Union and Confederate soldiers that was fought over the control of the Tennessee River. The existence of drums during this period aided the military troops by allowing them to communicate, march accordingly, and relay commands from generals who strategically adapted to changing battlefield conditions, playing a significant role by responding to immediate threats. After the Civil War, the technology of telephones and military communication evolved, making the drum-based method of communication obsolete on the battlefield. As a result of telecommunication, the purpose of drums in the military shifted to a means of artistic expression and entertainment, introducing a new spectrum of cultural music with jazz, parades, and artistic use of drums during the early 20s.

Before drums were utilized in the U.S. military, their historical significance can be traced in different countries dating back to the ancient civilizations of the Roman Empire.<sup>1</sup> Through efficient communication tactics, the Roman military claimed and shaped their civilization with successful battle victories won using drums on the battlefield. In turn, these tactics influenced future civilizations such as France, Britain, and later the United States. This historical impact becomes relevant when considering the United States' utilization of drums during their pursuit of gaining their independence during the Revolutionary War since drums played a crucial role in efficient communications to maneuver troops. Like the Roman Empire, the Americans had a desire to build a new civilization. Although drums were used in the time of the Roman Empire, it

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<sup>1</sup> John, Norris. *Marching to the Drums: A History of Military Drums and Drummers*. Stroud: Spellmount, 2012. 23. This book is my primary source that contains all the history of drums used in the military from the earliest date of the Roman era to the American Civil War. This primary source helped me to discover the cultural drums from different countries and how they used them to their advantage in their military tactics. Most of my main points regarding the historical context of drums in the military are from this source.

is not certain that they were the absolute oldest, especially considering that China, as early as 684 BC, had a well-established civilization predating the Roman Empire's existence.<sup>2</sup> While the exact origins of drums remain uncertain, their basic design allowed different cultural countries to shape and restructure them according to their preferred technique of hitting the drum to communicate from a vast distance.

Comparable to the extremely loud U.S. rope tension snare drum, the *taiko* drum is an example of a culturally shaped drum that arrived in China from Japan during the Yayoi period in 500 BC and was used on the battlefield to signal devices.<sup>3</sup> The *taiko* snare drum is as loud as the U.S. snare drum and can top over 130 decibels, which is good for long-range hearing when it is struck. The U.S. military drums were also used to get their soldiers ready for roll calls and sergeant calls. It is similar to the *dhol* drum, another developed cultural drum that was crafted and used to wake troops from sleep in the military boot camps of India.<sup>4</sup> It was originally made for traditional dances in India but was later adopted in their military tactics. As drums evolved in various cultural contexts, their role extended beyond communication aids for the U.S. military soldiers. In Thailand, the sound of drums was used to fuel and train their weaponry tanks, and in this case, the “tank” was an elephant, to taunt and overcome enemies.<sup>5</sup> Thailand's use of drums as an extra means of combat to cue their weaponry tank was very effective in aiding soldiers on the battlefield. This evolution finds parallels in the U.S., where the use of drums expanded beyond

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<sup>2</sup> History of Drums. “History of Military Drums.” Accessed on November 08, 2023. <http://www.historyofdrums.net/drum-history/military-drums/#:~:text=Africa%2C%20Middle%20East%2C%20India%20and,by%20West%20African%20Serer%20people>). This website features a comprehensive timeline illustrating the usage of drums, including their military applications. This timeline reveals that there is no single civilization with conclusive evidence of the oldest drum usage. To avoid having biased information on the timeline of drums, I have incorporated this source in my research.

<sup>3</sup>

Norris, *Marching to the Drum*, 24.

<sup>4</sup>

Norris, 26.

<sup>5</sup> Norris, 26.

military functions of communicating to encompass art expression. Even though drums were culturally crafted in various countries, they all had the same goal and effect: boost morale, relay commands, and taunt enemies.

With the influence of drum style in the U.S. by the French and British armies, the awareness of drums started to appear in more military strategies of different nations. The military tactics of drum usage by Mamelukes (armies from the Middle East) also influenced nations like the British, French, and Napoleonic armies to incorporate drums in their military strategy as well, serving as the grandfather of the usage of drums in military strategies in the United States.<sup>6</sup> The Mamelukes were slave soldiers who diligently served their Muslim rulers and worked their way up to the high ranks of other generals by building trust with their masters. They learned their drum usage tactics from the Mongols and established their drum corps (also known as the *Tablkhanah*), which rose in rebellion and overthrew Turanshah (a Kurdish ruler of Egypt) to seize the throne of Egypt during the Seventh Crusade in 1250.<sup>7</sup> The effect of drums back in the 5<sup>th</sup> century was so powerful that the Byzantine armies in the eastern part of the Mediterranean area formed a tactic to fish out Drum Masters and kill them to disrupt their means of communication with other troops, which was done to the Turkish army.<sup>8</sup> As the history of drums began to transcend and grow in battlefields from other nations, this evolution was attained in the pivotal role of drums, especially evident in the Battle of Shiloh during the American Civil War.

Drums were introduced in the United States military during the Revolutionary War in 1775.<sup>9</sup> The war lasted for about eight years, and drums used in the military during this time were

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<sup>6</sup> Norris, 33.

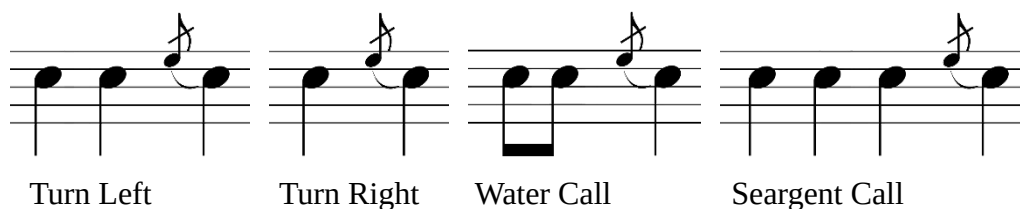
<sup>7</sup> Norris, 36.

<sup>8</sup>

Norris, 30.

<sup>9</sup> Jayson K. Dobney, "Military Music in American and European Traditions." *Heilbrunn Timeline of Art History* (New York), October 2004. [https://www.metmuseum.org/toah/hd/ammu/hd\\_ammu.htm](https://www.metmuseum.org/toah/hd/ammu/hd_ammu.htm).

to boost morale by cheering the military troops, regimenting, and communicating, much like it is seen in other countries.



*Figure 1: Lyrical Notes played by the U.S. Military Drummers.<sup>10</sup>*

The prominent role of drums in the Revolutionary War not only influenced the military strategies of the time but also left a lasting impact, as this tactic was incorporated into subsequent conflicts, including the American Civil War's Battle of Shiloh in 1862. This battle between the Confederates (led by General Albert Sidney) and Union soldiers (led by General Ulysses Grant) over the Tennessee River resulted in several casualties. Johnny Clem, a famous drummer boy from Ohio who tried enlisting in his local regiment but was denied due to his young age, later found his way to the 22<sup>nd</sup> Massachusetts Regiment as a drummer. Since he was too young to be on the official list of troops and drummers to be paid, the officers donated \$13 per month to keep him afloat and fund his uniforms.<sup>11</sup> His service as a drummer boy, especially during the Battle of Shiloh went beyond musical melody or harmony; it became a means of communication and organization during a chaotic era. The purpose of drums was multi-faceted. Johnny relayed crucial commands that coordinated the movements of troops in the midst of combat, enhancing the soldiers' ability to function as a unit. He provided a steady rhythm that offered some sense of order amidst the chaos, boosting the morale of fellow soldiers and maintaining discipline on the

<sup>10</sup>

George Washington's Mount Vernon. "Music in the Revolutionary War." Accessed October 28, 2023. <https://www.mountvernon.org/george-washington/the-revolutionary-war/music/>. This website also has the musical signal notes played by drummer boys to direct troops and sergeants as they march onto the battlefield.

<sup>11</sup>

Norris, 172.

field. His drumming served as a beacon of hope and determination, reminding everyone that they were part of something greater than themselves: the Union cause. Despite his instrument getting blown up in the chaotic battle with Confederate soldiers, he still managed to make himself useful by getting the injured soldiers to the medics for immediate treatment. Johnny Clem's remarkable service and bravery made him a symbol of the enduring spirit of those who found alternative paths to serve their country during this turbulent period in American history. He was later nominated by President Grant (the Union Army's General) to attend the West Point Military Academy to recognize his aid during the war.<sup>12</sup> Drummers like Johnny Clem, though young and unable to engage in direct combat, found profound significance in their roles.

Many countries around the world had similar tactics to the U.S. military involving drums to convey orders, coordinate troop movements, and uphold discipline. Each nation had its distinct drumming traditions, rhythms, and signals, which were intricately tied to its military culture and strategies. The French's military utilization of drums was mainly for coordination and communication on the battlefield. In 1534, Francois the First, the French King during that time introduced drummers into their Infantry not to play music but to transmit signals and orders to troops.<sup>13</sup> Since the voice of a soldier was not loud enough, especially on a chaotic field, they had to train them to learn the drum calls. The first manuscript book that had the score of the drum calls for the French Army was the *L'Orchesographie*.<sup>14</sup> This manuscript contains detailed instructions for military music, drumming, marching, and a few other musical aspects of the military. Their calls were not only to give orders but to help soldiers during their travels and

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<sup>12</sup> Norris, 173.

<sup>13</sup> Thierry Bouzard. "French Instructions for drums, 1754." *Coimbra IGEB*, (2012): 1-10.  
[https://www.academia.edu/7991279/French\\_Instruction\\_for\\_drums\\_1754](https://www.academia.edu/7991279/French_Instruction_for_drums_1754).

<sup>14</sup> Arbeau Thoinot. *L'Orchesographie*. Langres: Lehan des Preyz, 1596.

identify each regiment.<sup>15</sup> Even though the United States military style of drums was similar to the French's style with the sense of having the same purpose of relaying commands, they still had different tactics on how they executed said commands and used them also to differentiate which troop regiment was playing and marching. Like the U.S., the British military army in the Victorian era also had young drummer boys between the ages of 12 and 25, similar to the ages of U.S. military drummer boys.<sup>16</sup> They would carry their side drum, which looked like the U.S. rope tension snare drum, and beat their drums as they marched along the battlefield.

Not only were drums utilized to relay sergeant or general calls to the troops on the battlefield, but they were also assigned to whip and punish soldiers who were sentenced to be flogged.<sup>17</sup> Many children in Britain during this time period were motivated to join the army because drummer boys were loved by the Victorians, despite several young boys dying on the battlefield. The Victorian painters had a lot of paintings from the 19<sup>th</sup> century showing several drummers to honor their deaths.<sup>18</sup> Even an academic painter from France made oil canvas paintings in the 19<sup>th</sup> century of historical drummer boys who fought for their country and impacted the outcomes of battles by helping the soldiers communicate.<sup>19</sup> This paralleled the United States' approach to honoring and acknowledging drummer boys. However, in contrast to artistic portrayals, the U.S. chose to feature them in newspapers and awarded the ones that

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<sup>15</sup> Thierry Bouzard, "French Instructions for Drums, 1754." 2.

<sup>16</sup> National Army Museum "Age of Revolution: Drum of the 1<sup>st</sup> Foot Guards." Accessed on November 08, 2023. <https://ageofrevolution.org/200-object/drum-of-the-1st-foot-guards/#:~:text=Drums%20were%20an%20integral%20part,%E2%80%9CBy%20Beat%20of%20Drum%E2%80%9D>.

<sup>17</sup> National Army Museum, "Drum of the 1<sup>st</sup> Foot Guards."

<sup>18</sup> National Army Museum.

<sup>19</sup> Albert Boime. "Thomas Couture's Drummer Boy Beating a Path to Glory." *Bulletin of the Detroit Institute of Arts* 56, no. 2 (1978): 108–31. <http://www.jstor.org/stable/41504613>. This journal article narrates the significant impacts that the painted drummer boys had on their country before they died. It has awesome oil paintings of these historical drummer boys if you'd like to see them.

survived a Medal of Honor, underscoring their courage and valuable contributions to the military. The use of drums in military operations transcended national boundaries, with each country developing its unique drumming traditions and signals. The similarities in purpose across nations highlight the universal importance of drummers in warfare, while the differences in execution reflect the diverse military strategies and cultural nuances of each nation. The legacy of young boys and men using drums celebrated through art and recognition, serves as a testament to their enduring impact on military communication and the outcomes of historical battles.

As the drums in the military shaped the strategies and coordination of warfare, the advancement of technology would later reshape how military commands and information were passed across with telecommunications. The idea of telecommunications in the United States was in the minds of the people in the Revolutionary War fighting for their country. A man like Benjamin Franklin (who was an important diplomat for the colonies during that time) wanted to protect the information he had to negotiate with the French court for an alliance with them and a treaty of commerce. He was worried his protected information would get into the hands of the British people because Dr. Edward Bancroft, someone that he relied on as his secretary and interpreter, was a spy and a scholar (Double Agent) who worked for the British.<sup>20</sup> Franklin wanted to find a faster way to relay that information before the British got it, but unfortunately, the evolution of communications did not start until the nineteenth century.

With the evolution of drums being used as a means of communication, relaying commands, and performing other military duties still in use, other means like photography, telephone, telegraphs, coded messages, and radios were developed. Communication, a crucial element on the battlefield, connected soldiers and everyone on the battlefield. Photography

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Winkler, Jonathan Reed. "Telecommunications in World War 1." *Proceedings of the American Philosophical Society* 159, no. 2 (June 2015): 162-168. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/24640213>.

played a dual role by serving as a means of communication. An example of this was fostering a visual connection between families and troops during the Civil War, the first war experience for many, while also conveying visual messages to generals and soldiers not physically present on the battlefield.<sup>21</sup> In late 1862, photos became common, even though the technology was not available to the military at the time, a photograph that captured a moment on the battlefield told many stories to the families and people who were at home or in the cities, trying to feel connected and caught up with what was going on the battlefield.

Amid drums still being of use, the telegraph was another technological revolution that was silently unfolding. The telegraph was one of the truly developed innovations in the 19<sup>th</sup> century.<sup>22</sup> It changed the way people communicated as it was fast, efficient, and an effortless way of relaying messages to people. Unlike the drum, which is loud and requires considerable effort to play specific rhythms for communication, telegraphy offered a more efficient and reliable means of transmitting messages. The drum's sounds, especially over long distances on a chaotic battlefield, may sometimes take time to reach their intended destination and could be muffled or distorted by surrounding noise and debris from the battlefield. On the other hand, the telegraph employed a relatively effortless key-based system that swiftly conveyed messages with a high degree of clarity. This discrete and rapid method of communication becomes especially advantageous when troops seek to maintain a tactical edge by minimizing their presence and noise on the battlefield, something that could not possibly be done with the use of drums. For the modern technology to be effective they had to surround the whole country and railroad tracks

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Dr. Thomas, Flagel R. "Communications in the Civil War." *Virginia Center for Civil War Studies at Virginia Tech*. Accessed November 3, 2023. <https://www.essentialcivilwarcurriculum.com/communications-in-the-civil-war.html>.

<sup>22</sup> Jim Marshall. "Communication Revolution of the 19<sup>th</sup> Century" *American History, ABC-CLIO*. 2019. Accessed PDF November 04, 2023. <https://www.somersschools.org/cms/lib/NY01913963/Centricity/Domain/1252/American%20History%20-%20Communication%20Revolution%20of%20the%2019th%20Century.pdf>.

with telegraph wire.<sup>23</sup> The inventor of the telegraph, Samuel Morse, later adapted his coding scheme into letters and numbers, which birthed the operation and use of *Morse Code*.<sup>24</sup> The military use of Morse code was a groundbreaking method of communicating especially at farther distances that the sounds of drums could not reach. It became a universal call in different countries and people who were stranded on islands and deserts, using the infamous “SOS” distress signal (· · · – – – · · ·).<sup>25</sup> The Morse code was later replaced with the radio because it had real-time communication, eliminating the need for troops to learn Morse code operating skills and making the use of drums in the military less pertinent. The Air Force, however, still utilizes Morse code to this day.

As the telegraph and Morse code were developed, electricity was in use as a means of power cable but was not fully utilized to its full potential until after the invention of the telephone. The audible pulse was the only way to communicate for the receiver on the other end to decode the message given with the pulse from the telegraph.<sup>26</sup> After utilizing the electric telegraph, the telephone was invented in 1876 by Alexander Graham Bell to convert voices into an electronic signal for transmission and simultaneously hear and replay those signal sounds (voices).<sup>27</sup> With telephones, the U.S. military was able to communicate at even greater distances,

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<sup>23</sup> Marshall, “Communications of the 19<sup>th</sup> Century.” 1.

<sup>24</sup> Marshall, 1.

<sup>25</sup> Senior Master Sergeant James M. Houle. “AFEHRI File 100.113- Essay on Morse Code Operators in the Air Force.” *Air Force Enlisted Heritage Research Institute*. February 21, 1996. Accessed PDF November 5, 2023. <https://www.airuniversity.af.edu/Portals/10/AFEHRI/documents/EnlistedHistory/houle.pdf>. For more context with the use of the Morse code in the military and its spread to the Air Force, you can read this research material written by a former Air Force Veteran which was approved and signed by the AFEHRI & EPC Representative, and the Director of the Air Force Research Institute at the time, Gary R. Akin.

<sup>26</sup> National Museum of the Marine Corps. “War Communications during WWI.” Accessed on November 7, 2023. [https://www.usmcmuseum.com/uploads/6/0/3/6/60364049/nmmc\\_wwi\\_military\\_communication\\_resource\\_packet.pdf](https://www.usmcmuseum.com/uploads/6/0/3/6/60364049/nmmc_wwi_military_communication_resource_packet.pdf).

<sup>27</sup>

NMMC. “War Communications during WWI.” 7.

especially in World War I. The U.S. Army on the Western Front was using telephones to communicate between the soldiers, marines, and commanders.<sup>28</sup> To put into perspective, the telegraphs were like sending an email, which takes up to minutes or days for a response, whereas the telephones were like a direct phone call, receiving real-time information on the other end of the line. With the improvement of telegraphs to telephones, it became clear that the use of drums was obsolete on the battlefield. As technology advanced in the United States, other countries were also trying to have the very best assets and technology in their armory. Even though drums were still active as a method of communication in the military, they were not as prominent as during the time of the Civil War. Modern technology significantly shifted the primary means of communication to more sophisticated devices like telephones, telegraphs, and later in WWII, radio communications.

Radio technology has been around for a while even in its earliest form of the telegraph, but it was later discovered that the radio waves in radio technology could be used for other purposes.<sup>29</sup> They were of vital use when it came to intercepting and decoding enemies' radio transmissions, especially in World War I, which gave the U.S. army an advantage on the battlefield. Military communication in other countries also evolved to modern technology, and since this method of communicating was still in its infancy, it was easier for enemies who were brilliant in coding to exploit and hijack their information. The U.S. Radio Intelligence Unit was tasked with this job.<sup>30</sup> As radio technology continued to grow over the years, it became an essential part of not only the military strategy of long-range communication but also the

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<sup>28</sup> NMMC. "War Communications during WWI." 7.

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National Security Technology Accelerator. "A look at The Impact of Radio Technology on Military Applications." Accessed on November 09, 2023. <https://nstxl.org/radio-technology-on-military-applications/>.

<sup>30</sup> National Security Technology Accelerator.

civilian's life from weather forecasting to news reporting.<sup>31</sup> The use of radio in the military was a transformative era, rendering the old method of communication like drums on the battlefield obsolete. The initial development of the telegraph opened the door to other spectrums of communication with electricity and technology. The electrifying era of radio technology not only revolutionized warfare but also laid the foundation for a new era of interconnected communication.

With drums no longer needed as a means of communication on the battlefield, the purpose of the instrument shifted and found its groove in Jazz during the late 19<sup>th</sup> and early 20<sup>th</sup> centuries. Jazz originated in New Orleans and was comprised of African and European musical traditions that later evolved into various sub-genres like blues, swing, bebop, ragtime, and many other styles. Jazz got its rhythm, feel, “blues”, and playing expressively from African music and its harmony, chords, and instrument tune sounds from European music.<sup>32</sup> New Orleans, with its diverse ethnic group from around the globe, fostered a vibrant nightlife and a community of musicians who seized the opportunity to learn and perform collaboratively. Jazz, born out of the African-American experience and the evolution of spirituals and slave songs, found its roots in this dynamic and culturally rich environment.<sup>33</sup> With the introduction of jazz, the evolution of the drum set began, reimagining how the drums looked and how they were played by pulling traditional parts of drums from ethnic European and African countries, making the hybrid

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<sup>31</sup>

National Security Technology Accelerator.

<sup>32</sup> Hancock Institute of Jazz. “Where Did Jazz Come From?”. Accessed PDF on November 11, 2023. <https://hancockinstitute.org/media/Grade-7-9-JIA-Synopsis-4-Where-Did-Jazz-Come-From.pdf>.

<sup>33</sup> Hancock Institute of Jazz.

instrument.<sup>34</sup> This innovative fusion of percussion styles reflected the diverse cultural tapestry that characterized the jazz scene in New Orleans.

Historical pioneers in jazz who laid the foundation for the evolution were figures like Baby Dodd who was known for his innovative press rolls that later evolved to the standard style of jazz ride rhythm pattern.<sup>35</sup> He was the first to utilize a cymbal to keep time when playing both the bass drum and cymbal foreshadowing the way jazz drums are utilized now. Alongside him was a man who was marked by his distinctive use of hi-hat cymbals, Zutty Singleton, a self-taught drummer from Louisiana.<sup>36</sup> His adept use of hi-hats, adding intricate layers of rhythm, significantly influenced the incorporation of complex hi-hat rhythms in jazz. Their innovative techniques not only shaped early jazz drumming in the 1890s but also paved the way for a new purpose of entertainment for drums in the world of music. Transitioning into the swing era of jazz, drummers like Papa Jo Jones and Chick Webb further fueled the evolution of drums in the 1920s. Their use of the snare, bass, and cymbals created a driving beat that was heavily influenced by African rhythms. Chick Webb was known for his energetic style of drum solos and was one of the first drummers to use bass pedals which was influential and later integrated in modern drum sets.<sup>37</sup> As jazz drumming continued to progress with the freedom of people to artistically express themselves, Max Roach and other jazz drummers were influential in this era that was called the *Bebop Era* in 1940, expanding the creative possibilities of Jazz music.<sup>38</sup> Max

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<sup>34</sup>

Smithsonian Music. "The Birth of the Drum Set." Accessed on November 12, 2023.  
<https://music.si.edu/story/birth-drum-set>.

<sup>35</sup>

Rick Mattingly. "Warren Baby Dodds." *Percussive Arts Society*. Accessed on November 13, 2023.  
<https://www.pas.org/about/hall-of-fame/warren-baby-dodds>.

<sup>36</sup>

Modern Drummer. "Arthur Zutty Singleton: True Jazz Drumming Pioneer." Last Modified on December 16, 2019. <https://www.modrndrummer.com/2009/12/arthur-zutty-singleton/>.

<sup>37</sup>

Von Baron. "The Evolution of Jazz Drumming." *Von Baron Music*. Accessed on November 14, 2023.  
[https://vonbaronmusic.com/evolution-of-jazz-drumming/amp/#Early\\_Swing\\_Era\\_1920s-1930s](https://vonbaronmusic.com/evolution-of-jazz-drumming/amp/#Early_Swing_Era_1920s-1930s)

<sup>38</sup>

was known for developing a melodic polyrhythm using the ride cymbals which became a hallmark of jazz drumming in the modern age.

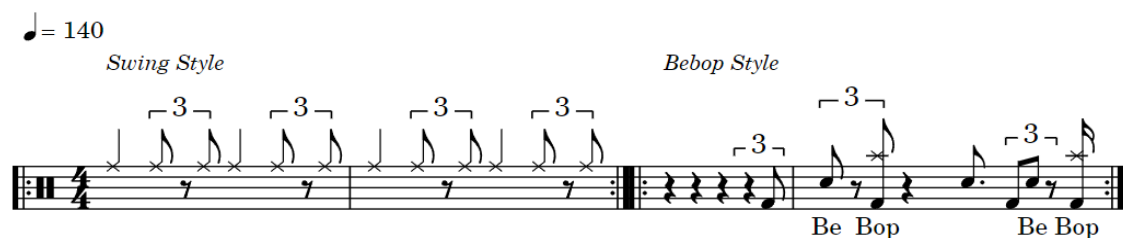


Figure 2: Contrast Jazz rhythm between the swing and bebop style.<sup>39</sup>

This journey of drums, marked by creativity, innovation, and shift in purpose, shows their enduring impact on the cultural landscape of the United States from the battlefields of war to the stages of entertainment and art expression. They transcended their original roles in military communications becoming a cornerstone of the musical genre, enjoyed not only in the U.S. but worldwide. With the dynamic evolution of jazz drumming techniques, where innovation and creativity have shaped the sound of the music, the one aspect that remained remarkably consistent was the traditional military grip. Despite the advent of new and experimental drumming styles in the world of jazz, the fundamental approach to holding the drum, horizontally in the traditional grip, has endured. This grip, originating from military drumming traditions, has transcended generations, maintaining its relevance even as drum designs transformed. Even as rope-tensioned snare drums were reimaged and crafted into smaller tuned snares in the evolution of drums and jazz, the traditional grip persisted. It became a bridge between the rich history of military drumming and the contemporary expression of jazz rhythm.

<sup>39</sup> Von Baron, "The Evolution of Jazz Drumming."

Olabowale Olufiade. *Jazz Rhythm Notes*. This musical sheet figure represents my original jazz rhythm piece, written through doing research and listening to songs in the Jazz Swing and Bebop Era. Utilizing Flat.io, a musical notation software, I transcribed my creative exploration into a tangible musical composition to show how jazz music has progressed over time.

The contrast between the traditional and innovative drum techniques underscores the enduring influence of historical practices in shaping the artistic landscape of jazz and entertainment.

The drum's role in military communication during the American Civil War to their transformation into a dynamic force in the world of jazz, age, and race emerge as crucial threads in this narrative tapestry. The initial use of drums in warfare, embodied by figures like the young drummer boy Johnny Clem, showcased how age limitations on direct combat engagement led to alternative roles, underscoring the impact of youth's utilization of drums for military communications on the battlefield. Meanwhile, jazz drummers like Baby Dodds, Zutty Singleton, and Chick Webb, among others, played pivotal roles in laying the foundation for various jazz genres. Their innovative techniques not only shaped early jazz drumming in the 1890s but also paved the way for a new purpose of entertainment for drums in the world of music. The diverse cultural origins of drumming traditions, evident in the distinct styles of European nations like France and Britain, and the origin of African slave songs for entertainment, contributed to the fusion of African and European influences in the birth of the jazz drum set. Jazz, emerging in New Orleans with its rich ethnic tapestry, became a cultural melting pot where rhythms and sounds transcended racial boundaries. This evolution, shaped by technological advancements like the telegraph and radio, ultimately rendered military drumming obsolete, leading to the drum's rebirth in this vibrant world of jazz. In this dynamic process, the traditional military grip persisted as a testament to the enduring influence of historical practices, acting as a bridge between the past and the contemporary expression of jazz rhythm. Thus, the drums, once a tool of war, now resonate as a symbol of cultural diversity, artistic innovation, and the enduring spirit of human expression.

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